

Getting Started with PHP, the Popular Programming Language

This article provides an introduction to PHP – the development process, its history, as well as its pros and cons. At the end of the article, we learn how to install XAMPP on a computer, and to write code to add two numbers.



If you refer to any Web technology survey to check the market share of different server side scripting languages, you will be surprised to know that PHP is used by an average 70 per cent of the websites. According to w3techs.com, “PHP is used by 82.7 per cent of all the websites whose server-side programming language we know.” In the early stages, even Facebook servers deployed PHP to run their social networking application. Nevertheless, we are not concerned about the Web traffic hosted by PHP these days. Instead, we will delve deep into PHP to understand its development, its history, its pros and cons and, in the end, we will have a sneak peek into some of the open source IDEs which you can use for rapid development.

First, let's understand what PHP is. It is an abbreviated form of 'Hypertext Pre-processor'. Confused about the sequence of the acronym? Actually, the earlier name of PHP was 'Personal Home Page' and hence the acronym. It is a server side programming language mainly used to enhance the look and feel of HTML Web pages. A sample PHP code embedded into HTML looks like what follows:

```
<!DOCTYPE HTML>
<html>
  <head>
    <title>Example</title>
  </head>
  <body>
    <?php
      echo "I am PHP script!";
    ?>
  </body>
</html>
```

In the above example, you can see how easily PHP can be embedded inside HTML code just by enclosing it inside `<?php` and `?>` tags, which allows very cool navigation between HTML and PHP code. It differs from client-side scripting languages like JavaScript in that PHP code is executed on the server with the help of a PHP interpreter, and only the resultant HTML is sent to the requester's computer. Though it can do a variety of tasks, ranging from creating